by 150 per cent. But rather than bring him cheer, it has Malik worried. "Right now, it is a warlike situation. There is a scramble for labourers and packaging material etc.," he says. "Prices have shot through the roof, but the returns are not promising." Early this month, he had to sell two of his consignments at throw-away prices in Delhi.

As plucking began in September, thousands of fruit-laden trucks departed the Valley for different states. But they were stopped by the authorities for days together along the treacherous mountainous Srinagar-Jammu National Highway 44. Malik's consignments took seven days to reach Delhi's Azadpur Mandi instead of the two days it should take to cover a distance under 900 km. The apples rotted in transit, fetching Malik only Rs 650-700 as against Rs 1,200 or more. The prices further declined ahead of Diwali with a box being sold for Rs 400-600 as a glut of them entered the *mandis* in a single day. According to growers, it costs Rs 500 to prepare a box of apples (not including the freight charges).

The growers alleged that trucks were 'deliberately' stopped to crush them. In protest, they shut down *mandis* across Kashmir for two days beginning September 25. The J&K administration swung into action and removed the SSP (Traffic), Ramban sector of the highway. The authorities, however, reason that the trucks were stopped at Qazigund in Kashmir as vehicular traffic on both sides is regulated on alternate days due to narrow stretches and construction. The highway—often shut by landslides—is the main surface link between Kashmir and the outside world with a carrying capacity of 3,000 to 3,500 heavy motor vehicles per day.

Bashir Ahmad Basheer, president of the Kashmir Valley Fruit Growers-cum-Dealers Union, says that growers, buyers and dealers are in total distress. With *mandis* overflowing with fruit, the demand has not been able to keep up. "It will take several years to compensate for the losses," he laments. Basheer says that the government should buy the low-quality apples to give some relief to the growers. He met Union home minister Amit Shah in Srinagar early last month to press for his demand. Since then the Lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha-led administration has initiated a slew of measures, with chief secretary Arun Kumar Mehta monitoring the traffic situation. As a result, delays on NH-44 have come down to four days.

The prolonged halt on the NH has hit the exporters too. Pulwama-based entrepreneur Izhan Javid, 28, who runs Fruit Master Agro Fresh J&K, which supplies apples to the UAE-based retail giant Lulu Group, rues the transportation delay. He notes that they have managed to dispatch six containers to the UAE this season and another 2-3 are on their ways. But it took one container 8-10 days to reach the Mumbai port. "They reached Dubai only in four days," he says. Internationally, too, exporters rue the decline in prices. Javid attributes this partly to the delay on the Srinagar highway; the global recession following the pandemic and duty-free apples being imported from Iran under the Free Trade Agreement are some of the other factors. Huge consignments are shipped through sea routes and the Attari-Wagah border via Afghanistan, hitting domestic sales. "Kashmir apples enter the markets late with deteriorated quality due to the long wait in trucks. But Himachal Pradesh's produce reaches markets swiftly fetching good amounts." Javid demands GST waiver on packaging material like Himachal does to give some relief to Kashmir's farmers.

APPLE GROWERS ARE HIT BY MULTIPLE ISSUES, INCLUDING DISRUPTIONS IN THE SUPPLY CHAIN AND SHORTAGE OF COLD STORAGES AND LABOUR

Dr Tariq Rasool, a plant pathologist at the Sher-e-Kashmir University of Agricultural Sciences and Technology of Kashmir, says that more than the highway blockade, the lack of mechanised horticulture techniques and the traditional landscape of orchards are contributing to farmers's losses. A grower in Europe, for instance, sells apple at less than one Euro per kg because of low input costs using advanced farming machinery. Instead of the 200-800 litres of water spray needed per hectare, growers in Kashmir have to use 4,000-8,000 litres. This high input cost forces the growers here to sell their crop at more than Rs 50 per kg. "We should mechanise horticulture. For example, using drones for spray can reduce cost by 45 per cent," says Rasool.

Manzoor Ahmad Mir, deputy director of horticulture, central planning and marketing, says that besides the highway congestion crisis, the oversupply in markets and lack of proper sorting are also responsible for low prices. He also claims that the lack of cold storage space is forcing growers to distress-sell their produce. Till last week, Kashmir had shipped out 960,000 tonnes of apple of the total 1.9 mt it produces annually.

The government, says Mir, brought buyers and growers together on an online platform. But their past experiences make the farmers sceptical. In the months following the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019, the government had introduced a market intervention price scheme to stop distress sales of the apple harvest. The central scheme, which involved direct procurement of 1.2 mt of fruit from the farms, hoped to raise the profits of growers by Rs 2,000 crore. "Deputing 20-25 staffers and experts at each centre incurred huge cost," he says. "Only 15,800 tonnes was lifted from five collection centres, forcing them to abandon the scheme." It's clearly a bitter harvest for Kashmir's apple growers this season. ■